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Nicki Parrott Part II
(The Covid Interview)

The Covid-19 pandemic impacted the music and arts community particularly hard. Musicians who had previously been interviewed for the Fillius Jazz Archive graciously shared their experiences during this virtual shutdown period. The political and racial unrest occurring simultaneously was also addressed.

Nicki was interviewed via Zoom on June 2, 2020, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm happy to have my guest Nicki Parrott here today, remotely unfortunately, but I did think it was worth gathering some stories for the Fillius Jazz Archive about how musicians and artists are making out these days. And we've seen some very upbeat examples of how you're making out with your new online adventure and really enjoying Chez Nicki Jams.

NP: Thank you. I'm so glad you are. I've had some really nice feedback from it because it feels like an escape but it's also supporting a good cause, the World Central Kitchen, and they are needed right now. They are world-wide. They were helping in Australia when the bush fires were in Australia in January of this year and they're helping out during the pandemic, you know, countless meals everyday, hoping to keep restaurants open to cook the meals for families. So that's nice. It's sort of — it started because we were all here and you know I haven't had a gig since March 12 I think was the last gig. I cut a European tour short. And you know all three of us sitting here — Andrew is here from — my stepson — is here from San Francisco. He works at Apple. Also closed. So he has certain technology/computer skills. Brian has audio recording and video skills which he needs for his work. We are all working from home. And I'm here kind of playing and doing a little online teaching. But I've been cooking a lot. And it sort of started as a joke, "Why don't you make pineapple pizza and we'll film it and then you play a song?" I'm like, "Naa, that would never work." And so I thought well let's try it. If it's fun we'll do it. And it was fun. We did one episode and we said well let's do it weekly for a while. We've committed to six. We just filmed number five, we've aired number four. And then we'll promote it at a time that feels right. We'll do the six, put them aside, and then figure out — we've made some money. It's a good cause, good charity, and we'll see what happens next with it you know. But it's fun and it puts all our skills to use so it's been a good thing to do together.

MR: Yeah, I have one suggestion with episode four — you could have another subtitle, like how to use the electric bass in the kitchen. I wondered if that was —

NP: Yeah my dad was angry at that, he said that was really stupid. I said well that's the point. We're not trying to take ourselves too seriously. You know I thought well let's just grab the bass and we'll pound the chicken. My husband looked at me and he said, "No you're not going to do that." I said, "Watch me," and I just did it. He says, "I don't know if we're going to use it." And I said, "Yeah, you will." And he did. Because I give him sort of the choice of how to edit because it takes us, because it's two people doing the job of ten here. You know we're trying to do multiple camera shoots but it's only the two of us. And so we're trying to — oh what was I going to say, you know, figure out how to — so it takes so long, he has to do so much editing. And he has good taste so I leave all the editing choices up to him and edit down what would be like three or four hours into under fifteen minutes if possible.

MR: So you are a person who for years has played almost constantly, at least from what I can see.

NP: I didn't realize that until the pandemic. Yes I've played constantly for 32 years.

MR: Was there — sometimes you hear the term, "I had an aha moment." And I wonder if you had an "Uh oh" moment when cancellations started to come in. Did they come all in at once?

NP: Actually it was very stressful because I had just started a tour. I started the tour on March 1, and I was working January and February in the States. So we did the jazz cruise, we came home, went to San Diego came home, went to Florida came home. So I had a pretty full January and February and actually a pretty full year booked you know. Some of the tours I do in Europe are organized two years in advance. So this particular one in March was two years in the making, which is a lot of phone calls, a lot of emails, a lot of work, Not necessarily for me but for the European musicians who organize them. So it was going to be a very busy five weeks but all great gigs, I was really looking forward to it. We got to about March — we got to my birthday, which was March 9, and we had a little party. It was a night off, and we had a little party in Germany and it was getting really strange then because these are people I've known for at least ten years and they all wanted to hang out with me and have coffee and cake and just hang out. And it was just like so weird because I couldn't really be near them and it was just a strange situation back in March. And then some gigs were cancelling. Some gigs at the end of March were cancelling and I was like well I'll probably go home sooner but I don't know when. And then the Europe flight ban happened, which was a couple of days after my birthday, three days after the birthday, so like March 12 the Europe ban was announced. And Brian called me and said, "You've got to come home," and I said, "I agree." So even though

gigs next week and the week after weren't cancelled, I cancelled them and they were not happy with me. In fact some of the contracts, some of the promoters were actually saying, "You owe us money." You know what I mean? "You can't cancel out of these gigs." Of course the gig cancelled but I was just ahead, a day ahead even. And I felt bad because I left certain band leaders and promoters in the lurch. I was on the phone for three hours to United trying to get a flight home. I got one via Heathrow, because I thought well they haven't banned in the U.K. yet, if I have to be overnight in the U.K. I can still get home to the States. And so I got a flight on the Friday which was the day after the Europe ban — well the day when it was going to get a lot harder to get back to the States. And I got one through Heathrow and I got on the plane at Heathrow and it was packed, and the Brubeck Brothers were on board because they had just finished a week at Ronnie Scott's. And unfortunately I believe that Dan had a brief episode with Corona that was not pleasant at all, so that was sad. I was talking to Chris on the plane and his wife and they cancelled, that was a big year for them because it was the hundredth anniversary of Dave Brubeck and they had a lot of work in Europe booked and they were on the same flight.

MR: We met them at the jazz convention in New Orleans, they were doing the Brubeck thing.

NP: Yeah, Chris Brubeck actually lives in not far from here in Wilton, I believe near where Dave lived, Dave Brubeck. Super sweet guys. Great guys.

MR: You anticipated a question I was going to ask and that is most musicians were sitting waiting for the phone to ring and the more it rang, the more we knew what was coming. Like okay this is cancelled, now who's next? But I was going to ask if you had to initiate cancellations and indeed you have quite a —

NP: Yes because as you know, family comes first. So not only I couldn't get back to Australia — because I'd been on the road and that's the worst situation for a virus like this. So I knew I couldn't go back to Australia right away, then I wouldn't know how I would come back to Connecticut to be with my husband and stepson. So I had my parents on FaceTiming and said, "You've got to get out of Europe, you've got to get out now. And I said well I have to go home, I mean I have to come here. And fortunately I was able to get that flight. It was very stressful because I was also with two other American musicians, Paolo Alderighi and Stephanie Trick. We were doing some gigs together at the beginning of March. And they were also very stressed because Paolo's parents were in Milan but they couldn't get back to Milan because Italy was in a very bad way at that stage. And Germany was looking bad. And of course it hadn't really hit the U.S. quite as bad, it wasn't quite here yet, or it was quite here yet but we didn't really know about it. And that whole time was very stressful. But I'm glad I did the right thing and actually one of the promoters called the next day and cancelled and apologized for being so mad. And I was glad in a way you know? And of course cancellations keep coming, into

November now. I just talked to a European promoter this morning and they said, "Oh we might have you over for two weeks in September." I said, "Well it has to be worth the airfare and I have to know it's — I can get there and come home, back here, you know what I mean? So there's a lot more questions raised now about touring. I mean I used to get on a plane every other week like it was nothing you know. Now I have to think about my family. Now I have to think about travel routing and are there going to be flights back you know what I mean? And is the cost worth it if we're going to have less people in the hall and do more concerts you know, like some of the concerts we're going to have to do two concerts instead of one to get paid the same. So there's a lot of complications yet. So I've just basically thought, well September is three months away. And of course I want to play. I love being on the road. I always have you know. I enjoy being with musicians, I enjoy being on stage, I enjoy playing. But it has to feel right. And after that experience in March I don't want to rush out unless the circumstances are good.

MR: Do you feel responsible for the other musicians that you may be taking with you? Maybe I didn't ask that right, but is it a consideration about what they want to do also?

NP: Yeah. I mean it's very weird because when you commit to a gig and sign a contract, you know, you never want to cancel. It never feels right. I think a lot of the work in the fall, they're all European musicians. You know one's from France and the other two are in Germany. It's just a matter — well even that, that's a border to cross from France to Germany. I don't know if the musician there would be able to make it, and I have basically said to them, "If I can't make it, just find a sub for me." "Yes, but you sing and you play." "I know, well make the bass player sing." I don't know. I can't help you on that end but the priority has to be safety first, family, and not to rush into anything. I mean there's so many unknowns about this virus still. Second waves, third waves.

MR: Do you have booked gigs with Rossano and Eddie?

NP: Yeah we lost some. Yup. We had some in May, nice concerts, a couple of nice concerts we were supposed to do in May in Florida. A couple of jazz parties and hopefully December in Bern, Switzerland. We'll see if Marians in Bern is opened up. That's a beautiful club. I hope that happens.

MR: What does it do to your identity?

NP: That's the biggest question of all, isn't it? Because I've talked to a lot of musicians and you know it's — the word "reinvent" is not an easy word when you've spent your whole life committed to learning a craft, now just reinvent yourself. So yeah it's various ways of coping I think, depending on the financial situation too. You know it's not easy to get unemployment. I found that out. There were several grants going around but almost as quickly as they open up they close up. There's that many people that need help. So what does it do? It makes you focus on the — prioritize different things you know. I think at

first I resented the fact that I was the one going out shopping and cooking. And then I thought well I have a role to play here, to keep the house running. And I happen to like it and they like my food. And all the rest of it, you know, it's tough, it's a very personal question, not easy. I certainly got depressed about two weeks in, when everything was cancelling, even into June, July. Yes, I got really depressed. And I had to reassess. I had to, you know, I have a little bit of savings, I have a supportive group around me, I have a supportive family, I have a sister that's a musician and we talk all the time. Yeah. It hasn't been easy but I think that the key to it is to stay creative.

MR: Some people do very well when they have time to do other things.

NP: Yeah, that's not me.

MR: Not me either. It's amazing how little you can do with so much time.

NP: It's crazy, isn't it? I mean I'm mad at myself that I don't have a great music library all set up. I don't. It was one of the goals, and I have to get to it. You know what I mean? There's certain things you have to do. You kind of have piles of music around forever and think that you can be organized that way. It doesn't work. And I don't know when — earlier in the year Arbors Records and Venus Records both asked me to do a project, a recording project. That means writing arrangements. I've realized that I really don't work well without a goal, without a deadline. It's hard for me to work — I don't know what the first gig is going to be and who with, or the first series of gigs. So I almost sometimes don't know what to practice. It's crazy.

MR: You know I've been writing music for my college saxophone ensemble. I don't know if they're coming back yet.

NP: My sister sent that chart, I'll remind her if she didn't send the "Waltzing Matilda" chart.

MR: Yeah. With your online lessons, was this something you were doing before now?

NP: No. I was teaching — I have a student here. I wasn't teaching. I did the occasional FaceTime lesson, from the road often. Never did the Zoom format before, never. Now yesterday I taught a student, and this was very interesting, I taught a student in Tokyo early in the morning because of the time difference. And he said, "Last night you would have been performing 400 meters up the street from here." And that hit home, I was like, "That's right I was going to be in Japan." It was a big pre-Olympics thing with an all-girl Japanese orchestra and I was going to be the band leader. And it was going to be really exciting because they put together this really cool thing with all these Japanese women. It was going to be really fun. And the gig was cancelled of course, so the tour cancelled, even though I think Japan is recovering quite well actually, right now. And that was like, "Oh that's right, wow, yeah. Well thank you for having a lesson." You know. So you get little odd things like that, yeah, this is a different reality. We don't know what's coming out of this reality for musicians, you know what I mean? So online teaching and online

forums like TrueFire and other mediums like that, that's where I'm going to get stuck into because that's what I need to be doing right now.

MR: There was a week, I believe near the end of March, where it seemed like every other day there was an obit.

NP: That's right. Bucky Pizzarelli and Ruth Pizzarelli, and Wallace Roney and many others.

MR: And it just seemed like whoa, why is this hitting these older musicians with such regularity. And I remember thinking well Bucky was not in great health. We had almost lost him a couple of years ago.

NP: That's right.

MR: Somehow it just didn't seem fair that this took him.

NP: It wasn't fair at all, no. I agree, the saddest thing of all, I get chills thinking about it now, that John and Martin and Mary and the whole family — I don't know for sure but this disease was so awful that you couldn't be around your loved ones. That is just — I can't even fathom that. I can't fathom that. And of course Ruth going a week later you know. That's the saddest thing of all. It isn't fair you know what I mean? I mean he was such a survivor and such a wonderful guy. And I used to love driving him up to Hamilton, I just used to love chatting with him.

MR: Yes. We treasure those moments maybe more than we did.

NP: That's right, of course. Absolutely. Yeah. Special guy.

MR: Yes indeed. Do you have an opinion about your local, state or federal government, how they've handled this?

NP: Ooh.

MR: Tough one.

NP: It's a really tough one, and I know you can't compare to other countries but well I'm still waiting to hear back about unemployment and of course the PPP and all these other things, I mean it didn't work for me. I didn't have the necessary requirements for a lot of things here. Business accounts. Who knew you'd need a business account at your local bank? I mean I didn't know these things. So I can't say I'm impressed. Yes it's been an awful time for a lot of people. Federally I think the less I say the better.

MR: Do you think it's hard for you because — I lost track if you're a citizen or not.

NP: I became a citizen in January.

MR: Nice.

NP: After 26 years here. So I definitely feel like I'm part of the fabric of the country, you know what I mean? I mean I paid my taxes the first year and I've always been legal, and I've always wanted to do things the right way here you know. And I always — it was a beautiful ceremony in January. A very different time. Not so long ago, but a really different feeling in January. And there were, how many of us, I forgot the number of us

now, 55 or something at a court in Bridgeport. Was it Bridgeport? I think it was Bridgeport.

MR: Okay.

NP: And it was federal court and we all turned out, all dressed up. And it was a very moving speech that the judge gave and handed out certificates. And the next day I went down to the Passport Expedite Service in Stamford, and I got a passport in two hours. I could not believe it. I mean it was like, okay, that I'm impressed with. That impressed me because I said I'm going on a jazz cruise next week and I just became a U.S. citizen and I need a passport. And I said, "By the way I have to fly to North Carolina tonight for a jazz festival and I'll be back on Monday." And they said, "Give me a minute." And they went away and they came back and said, "Can you come back at 12:00 today?" I said, "Yes, my flight is not until 6. Absolutely." So I went away and had a cup of coffee, came back and got a passport. I couldn't believe it. I just became a citizen and the next day I had a passport. I thought well this is too good to be true. So some things do work when they're supposed to work and that was impressive you know? And I'm really glad because everything's been shut down since then and my case was already delayed way longer than it should have been because of the amount that I travel. So I had to get my local senator to contact Immigration and it was a process and a half to get there. So by the time we got to our ceremony it was oh, thank goodness, you know? It's done, I'm a citizen and I'm a dual citizen and I'm really proud to be a dual citizen. I want to vote. I want to participate. I want all the things that every citizen of a country wants, you know? Yes I think that things could have been handled way better and I really hope that things don't escalate in this country and get out of control, and that the good people shine through. The majority of people in this country are very good. And I believe that and I will still believe in that.

MR: What do your parents in Australia — do they make observations?

NP: Oh yes. The whole world does, don't they, about America. They love to talk about America. The whole world. All the time. Europeans, they call me, they talk about America. My family. My aunts, my uncles, my cousins, everybody wants to talk about America right now. We are in the world focus right now.

MR: Can you share what you are hearing?

NP: Dissatisfaction with the president. They like to talk about that. Fear about the next coming months, what it might bring and pain and anguish over the brutality of the George Floyd situation, the murder of this man, you know, and the consequences of that, and the protests. A lot of fear. I think the whole world is looking at America with what's next. And just hoping that we come out of this with some positivity and some leadership. We need leadership. That's what I feel. That's what's really lacking you know. There are

segments of it, you know, I feel like sometimes Andrew Cuomo in New York has done a good job at certain things. You know there are bits of good leadership, there are good cops shining through. There are people trying to lead the way and show positivity. We just need so much more of it.

MR: Okay. Thanks for sharing that.

NP: Well it's a hard subject to talk about because it's so sad you know.

MR: I'm trying to figure out how to phrase this question, I'll use my own experience as an example. Most of the gigs I play I have to move gear.

NP: Yes.

MR: I have a full sized digital keyboard and this and that. And that I don't miss.

NP: You know me too. I have to say my back's been better.

MR: Do you think there could be things that you will reconsider even doing when hopefully we get back to normal?

NP: Yes I think I've found that I do need a better work/life balance. I wasn't handling that well. I think every musician struggles with this. We don't like to say no.

MR: Yes. A gig is a gig.

NP: A gig is a gig, we like the routine of being busy and being on the road. You know? We get addicted to it, and I was addicted to it. And I've found that I do need more of a work/life balance. I'm not — I'm a long way from 30, you know what I mean? And you just don't think about things when you're younger and now it's like well I can use time off to do more things here at home. And so I do want to find that. I mean we don't know what we're going back to. And I certainly want to work on other things here, getting back to the question. Sorry I went way off the question. You know that's the big takeaway for me is I need to be better at scheduling so that I am at home more between, especially big tours. Five, six weeks now, that sounds like a long time. And it was nothing for me you know? Go out for five or six weeks, no problem.

MR: And the fact that you mentioned that some tours abroad may book you two years in advance, so you have to like extrapolate do I want to do that in two years. It's almost impossible to say.

NP: Yeah, it is impossible to say, except that's how a lot of the European promoters do things. They want you every other year. You know it's more annuals over here. Over here it's been more annual gigs, annual parties, annual things. But it doesn't mean you can't go to Europe but you have to go to Europe with band A, and then in the in between years you're with the other groupings, you know what I mean? It's complicated. They have a way of working it out. And these are all musicians mostly booking these gigs. Not agents. Networks. And you know some promoters, a few. And in Japan you cannot really go to Japan without a good promoter. You need a promoter for there. The language thing is just

too difficult. So Japan always a promoter, Europe not necessarily. Musicians book it. But they are two years apart, the tours.

MR: So on the lighter side, did you have to buy new pots and pans for your —

NP: You know Brian said to me yesterday, he said, "You know if you continue with this you really need new pans." I mean I'm looking at them and they're really old and you know and I'm trying not to show some of the baking trays that have, I mean who goes out and buys baking trays? We make do, right? You make do with everything now.

MR: I think it makes it more, "You can do this at home too."

NP: Yeah I know. I know. Yeah. Exactly. I did want to focus some of the recipes on that. The second one is four ingredients. The next one is — they're pretty simple I guess. Like the last one, the one last night, what was it, chicken schnitzel — you don't have to do the salad, you know what I mean? You can kind of just do what you want with it you know. But —

MR: You can plug in the side people.

NP: Yeah, exactly. You can choose your side musicians.

MR: Do you have anything you do when you start to get down?

NP: That's a very good question. I talk to musicians, I talk to friends, I talk to my parents, I talk to my sister, I talk to my husband a lot you know. I talk it through you know, and I try to figure out what is — I actually feel that I have to grieve the loss of the year's work. Basically it's going to be — what it comes down to is the rest of the year's work. It was so much work to put it together — plane tickets — the first few weeks of the quarantine were me on the phone to United trying to recoup what I could, because I paid out a lot in air tickets and they weren't reimbursing them. And I'm saying but the flights are cancelled, can't you just reimburse me the ticket? That was difficult. And so it was a combination of trying to figure out the unemployment, trying to see if there's any grants, or trying to figure all these things out. And it was just all at once. And it just, it left me depressed because I didn't get anywhere basically. I just got nowhere. And it was wasted hours it felt like, hours and hours on the phone and it was — yeah that got me down. That really got me down. And it got most musicians down because if you looked on FaceBook, if you talked to people, it was the same story. What are we going to do? This is bad.

MR: It may have been mistaken assuming that the people booking you would provide you with that airfare, pay for those tickets themselves.

NP: Yes. I've been booking them because you know I'm trying to get — I have a pretty good standing with United so I was trying to get United or United-affiliated flights. I always get compensated when I do the gig. So when the tour happens here's your money and here's your flight money you know. But you have to kind of book — you have to buy the

trip. And most people now, in the old days people always bought your flights. But in the last couple of years people are saying, "Try to get a flight around X amount." Or people know me, they know I'm not going to be booking a business class flight or a seat. People know that I'm trying to get something on United or something else that is comparable on fare, and in summertime you've kind of got to get them a little earlier because summertime flights, especially to Europe, used to be very expensive. So sometimes, well it's a negotiation, well that's too high, see if you can go on a budget airline this time you know. It's a lot of thought process that goes into getting the right flight you know. You can't always get a direct. So that's the thing, once you do the tour you are reimbursed. So that was a little bit of insult to injury because it was like the airlines, you're getting some money from the federal government, can't you just reimburse yourself? It doesn't always work the way you want it to. That's the lesson of all this.

MR: Yes. Well I appreciate your time, Nicki, and you've given us a lot of valuable information I think. You know people are going to be writing papers and, just like they did with Katrina in New Orleans, people studied the effects of that, so I'm sure we'll be doing that.

NP: Yes. Oh definitely. Like shoulda, woulda, coulda — there's going to be a lot of talk for months and years about this.

MR: Right.

NP: You know? Yes. Absolutely.

MR: And you can't slow down your schedule until we have you back at Hamilton.

NP: Oh, there are some of the greatest gigs up there, really, always fun and yeah. I've been coming up there for a long time it seems. So thank you.

MR: Okay. You take care and keep jamming in the kitchen.

NP: We'll do a couple of more episodes and then we'll reassess. Because it does take up a lot of time in the editing process but it's been a lot of fun.

MR: Great. I enjoyed reconnecting with you.

NP: Yes, me too. I did too. Thank you very much. Thanks for the opportunity.

MR: Right. Thanks a lot. Bye.

NP: Bye-bye. See you.